Tuticorin: S.S.V. Krishna Pillai and Annasami Aiyar, a vakil. Two, if not three, were from Colombo: A.V.R.A. Adaikkappa Chettiar and A.M. Sayed Ibrahim, both merchants, and S. Ramaswami Pillai. Four were from Sirkazhi: K. Chidambaranatha Mudaliar, Thirunarayana Pillai, M.T.K. Muthuswami Chettiar and T.S. Kuppuswami Pillai—at least two of whom, if not all, were land-owning magnates. Apart from C. Vijayaraghavachari, there were three directors from Salem: Annan Thirumalai Iyer, A. Arunachalam Chettiar and Pittah Ramaswami Iyer. Hassanussain Ravuthar, Dindigul; Seeni Hassanussain Ravuthar, Ramnad; A. Somasundaram, Cuddalore; W. Srinivasa Iyengar, Madras City; and D. Hanumantha Chetty, Somavarpet, Coorg were the other directors.[12] (Some sources mention M.R. Ramakrishna Aiyar and Kumaraswamy Reddiar but they do not figure in the prospectus issued on 24 September.[13]) Besides the large-scale induction of new directors, the few missing names were also not without significance. The absence of S.V. Nallaperumal Pillai, the primary promoter, is striking. Also missing was M.V. Maya Nadar, the only Nadar director.

It was alleged that VOC did less and less work for the company because of his increased involvement in politics, and therefore the new directors from Tirunelveli came over to Tuticorin to take charge of the company. It was argued that ‘respectable people of Tinnevelly should take up the management if they wanted to attract shares’—implying that VOC was a political hothead and therefore a liability to the company.[14] For VOC, shipping business and Swadeshi politics were two sides of the same coin. In his view, strident political campaigning only strengthened the company. But not all directors of the company were comfortable with his continued, and combative, political crusade. Having benefitted from the Swadeshi propaganda in terms of investments they were inclined to soft-pedal on it.

The *South Indian Mail* praised the new set of directors for ‘throw[ing] the weight of their influence in the cause of the company’ and ‘… the rapid sale of shares, nearly 4,000 being sold within the past two weeks, is an index of their zeal and sympathy’.[15] Praise apart, who were these new directors who would each have taken at least 100 shares to qualify for